AN ORIGINAL COUNTRY-HOUSE MYSTERY

THE LAST BELL OF ASHCOMBE HOUSE

SOLUTION GUIDE

SPOILERS. Keep closed until you have submitted your accusation. The first section contains optional graduated hints.



1-6 INVESTIGATORS | 90-120 MINUTES | AGES 14+

An autumn storm. Six suspects. One unfinished announcement.

HINT LADDER / NO CULPRIT NAME

Hints before answers

P1 / GENTLE, THEN STRONGER

Read the beginnings of the four lines, not the number of words. If needed, write the first letters of Frost, Oak, Under and Rain in order, then read the result as a number word.

P2 / GENTLE, THEN STRONGER

Treat an immediate pair as a block and reserve the fourth place for C. If needed, place the B-D block so A can stand after D. Read the value on the second label.

P3 / GENTLE

Use the replacement hour, not the cancelled hour. The note is from the previous day.

CASE / GENTLE

Separate the key-borrowing interval from a witnessed library visit. What does the photograph rule out?

CASE / STRONGER

Compare the afternoon-tear claim with E05 and the physical fit in E08. Then ask who needed the audit to disappear.

PUZZLE ANSWERS / SPOILERS BEGIN

The dispatch box opens

Task	Answer	Reason
P1	4	F-O-U-R, the first letters of the four lines, spells FOUR.
P2	1	Unique order B-D-A-C. The second label is D, carrying 1.
P3	7	The corrected appointment is seven in the evening.
Combined	417	Read P1, P2, P3 in that order. Open E09.

Why P2 is unique: C is fourth. B must stand immediately before D. If B-D occupied places 2-3, A could not stand after D because place 4 is C. Therefore B-D occupy places 1-2 and A occupies place 3.

P4 expected timeline: The essential interval is 9:10-9:20. Celia admits a visit beginning at 9:10; nobody verifies the claimed immediate return. The bell and thud occur at 9:14. She is seen in the archive with the torn cuff at 9:20.

P5-P6: These are reasoning worksheets, not additional numeric puzzles. Answers should cite evidence and distinguish corroboration from assumption. Accept equivalent wording.

THE ACCUSATION

Who killed Edmund Ashcombe?

Celia Ward caused Edmund's death. The intended private confrontation threatened to expose unauthorized sales, false authority letters and the diversion of 480 pounds into her private commission account.

Opportunity: E03 puts the cupboard key in her possession at 9:10, and she admits visiting Edmund. Her claim that she returned immediately to the archive has no witness. E12 provides a normal route to reach the archive well before the 9:20 observation.

Physical connection: E08 records a fitted fragment from Edmund's hand joining Celia's damaged right cuff. E05 shows that cuff intact at 9:05, then torn by 9:20. The claimed afternoon damage is false. Together, those facts place the contact inside the crucial interval.

Motive and confrontation: E06-E07 expose the false restoration story. E09 adds Edmund's denial of authority and his appointment with Celia before the announcement. It also explains why removing a sheet from the folio failed to erase the audit.

Likely method: During the confrontation at about 9:14, Celia struck Edmund with the brass bell. The interrupted ring, thud, injury and scene support this reconstruction. She left through the service passage and was seated in the archive by 9:20.

WHAT MAKES THE CASE STRONG

Neither debt, typewriter defect nor a broken alibi is enough alone. The dated intact cuff, physical fit, admitted meeting, false explanation and financial confrontation form the supported chain.

ELIMINATION & FAIR ALTERNATIVES

Why the other five fall away

Suspect	Pressure / reason for suspicion	Why the case is weaker
Nora	Debt and fear of disinheritance	Martha places her upstairs at 9:14. No cloth connection.
Felix	Threatened professional reputation	Telephone account has gaps, but no physical link or contradiction matching the cuff evidence.
Gideon	Questionable purchases and scandal	Investigator sees him in the gallery at the bell. His records expose the money trail.
Martha	Protective omission about Nora	Corrected account explains omission; upstairs with Nora. No matching torn cuff.
Arthur	Coal theft; heard service door	Hearing a door is not evidence of using it. Mud is not unique; no cloth link.

The case does not require every innocent person to have a perfect alibi. It requires a supported account that explains the decisive evidence. Suspicion of Felix or Arthur is reasonable early on, but does not explain the fitted cloth and the documented false claim.

Gideon may still have professional or financial questions to answer. Clearing a person of this killing does not certify every business decision they made.

RECONSTRUCTION / FACT VERSUS INFERENCE

The likely final minutes

Time	Supported event or reconstruction
9:05	Recorded: Celia's cuff is intact in plate G-17.
9:08	Recorded: Martha puts the bell on Edmund's desk.
9:10 onward	Recorded: Celia borrows the key and admits visiting Edmund. E09 confirms the planned confrontation.
About 9:14	Reconstruction: confrontation turns physical; Edmund catches the cuff, tearing it. Celia uses the bell. The sound and thud support the timing.
After the blow	Reconstruction: she tears the visible audit sheet from the folio and uses the service passage. No witness sees this removal or departure directly.
By 9:20	Recorded: Celia is at her archive desk; her cuff is torn.
9:22	Recorded: she returns the cupboard key.
9:32 onward	Recorded: scene preserved; comparison later records the physical cloth fit.

The exact spoken words, order of the grab and blow, and private thoughts are not known. Do not claim a confession or an exact medical death time. The narrative solution is the best-supported reconstruction of the supplied evidence.

EPILOGUE & SCORING

The truth that remained

When the documents were laid in time order, Celia's neat account could no longer contain them. The afternoon tear became a tear within fifteen minutes. The restoration fund became a private account. The vanished audit became a carbon copy inside a box.

Nora read the trust draft again, this time slowly. Martha asked whether the library could be closed until morning. Gideon offered to supply every record in his office. The constable took custody of the papers, the bell and the fitted cloth.

Nothing in the house had required a secret passage. What had been hidden was authority: who had been allowed to speak for Edmund, and how long that permission could be imitated. His last unfinished announcement had become the record that outlived him.

Case score / 10	Award
Culprit: Celia Ward	2
Motive: unauthorized sales and diverted proceeds threatened with exposure	2
Method and route: probable bell strike; ordinary service passage	2
Evidence chain: E05 + E08 and E03/E09, explaining their different roles	3
Reject an alternative using evidence rather than intuition	1

8-10: well-supported case. 5-7: right direction, missing links. 0-4: revisit claims versus observations. Hints do not reduce the score; reasoning matters more than speed.